



confess their feelings. Both are constrained by notions of honor. These unspoken desires heighten the sexual tension between them. “Crouching tiger, hidden dragon” is a Chinese expression alluding to a situation full of danger.

In Lee’s movie, chief among these dangers is suppressed sexual desire. Just when Shu Lien and Li Mu Bai seem about to overcome propriety and declare their love, Li Mu Bai’s sword, Green Destiny, is stolen, and he suspects his elusive archenemy, Jade Fox (Cheng Pei-

pei), the killer of his old master, to be the culprit. Before he can reveal his heart to Shu Lien, therefore, Li Mu Bai must recover Green Destiny and avenge his master’s death.

Women warriors

At this point in the narrative, it becomes clear that Lee is making a second major departure from the *wuxia* movie tradition by putting women to the fore. The sword thief, who is shown leaping away across the rooftops of the Forbidden City

Jen Yu rejects Shu Lien’s offer of friendship and the pair duel. Shu Lien fights with every weapon available, but each is destroyed in turn by Jen Yu wielding Green Destiny.

in a spectacular aerial chase, is in fact Jen Yu (Zhang Ziyi), a fiery young noblewoman who has been secretly trained in brilliant but uncontrolled combat skills by the villainous Jade Fox, also a woman.

Li Mu Bai’s ally and his two adversaries are three strong women who all have major roles in the plot and the fighting. It is Li Mu Bai’s beloved Shu Lien who plays the customary male part of sublime swordsman with Zen-like emotional control. Jen Yu and Jade Fox are their out-of-control opponents.

Jen Yu is in violent rebellion against the social and chivalric conventions Li Mu Bai and Shu

“Fighters have rules, too. **Friendship, trust, integrity.** Always keep your promise. **Without rules** we wouldn’t survive long.”

Shu Lien / Crouching Tiger, Hidden Dragon